most part, its religious and caste groups—fragmented, self-absorbed, inhabiting separate but adjoining physical and social spaces—forged a modus vivendi for coexistence. The very diversity that could have created conflict seems to have made it harder for people to rally behind narrow religious or political ideas. ‘While premodern Indians were certainly aware of religious difference,’ writes Eaton, ‘not a single communal riot is known to have occurred for almost all of medieval history.’[33] Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence, but this is still a startling remark. Even if Eaton is only substantially correct, it is no mean feat.

Another explanation may lie in a default ‘live and let live’ attitude, partly the by-product of an old otherworldly sensibility in the subcontinent—evident in the unorthodox mystical and pacifist traditions of Bhakti and Sufism. This fostered pluralism, distinct from the one in modern political thought, but valuable in its own way and still extant today. A significant factor is also the thick interdependence of communities on each other’s traditional trades and skills. For instance, while most weavers of Varanasi’s silk sarees are Muslim, most yarn suppliers and retailers of the finished products are Hindu, creating natural incentives to cooperate, maintain peace and oppose those who seek political mileage from communal polarization—a trend yet sadly on the rise, not just in Varanasi (which was also fuelled periodically in the twentieth century as competitive electoral politics grew, notably around Partition. Today, this fragile peace is again under threat as a weakening caste system and the religious right lead more people to see others as ‘just Hindus’. The new ‘Hindu’ identity increasingly transcends caste and ethnic identity and ironically feeds Hindutva nationalism. Stated differently, the old ‘division of labourers’ that Ambedkar diagnosed in the caste system is fading not to give rise to a casteless proletariat but to a sectarian nationalism).